

Email safety training handbook

Practical lessons for safer workplace decisions

Read the lessons, assess the practice examples, and keep the checklists beside your inbox. Complete the five-question knowledge checks inside the platform. A score of 80% or higher passes a lesson.

Your learning path

01. Spot phishing and impersonation - 7 minutes
02. Handle links and attachments - 8 minutes
03. Report and respond to suspicious email - 8 minutes
04. Verify payments and executive requests - 8 minutes
05. Protect passwords and sign-in approvals - 8 minutes
06. Recognize QR codes, texts, and phone scams - 7 minutes
07. Handle shared documents and data requests - 7 minutes
08. Use PhishAware results and reporting - 6 minutes

Reporting at work

Follow your company procedures. For an urgent incident, contact your security team directly as well as reporting through PhishAware. Keep passwords, approval codes, and confidential attachments out of support messages.

Edition: 3 October 2026. Original workplace scenarios. Official further-reading links appear under each lesson.

Spot phishing and impersonation

Recognize misleading senders and verify unusual requests before acting.

Learning goals

- Identify phishing and impersonation
- Check the address and request together
- Choose an independent verification channel

Understand the request

Phishing uses deception to obtain information, money, or access. In a workday, an unexpected task might arrive among genuine messages. Ask who benefits from the action and whether the request matches your responsibilities.

Separate a name from identity

A copied display name or logo is insufficient evidence of identity. Read the entire sender address. A different reply address deserves a check, but does not prove fraud by itself. An account belonging to a known person might also be compromised.

Verify before following instructions

Consider context, not spelling alone. Polished messages still deserve scrutiny. If an instruction feels unusual, use a contact already in your directory or an approved company channel. Keep approvals in place even when the sender insists on urgency.

Practice example: Your staff profile closes today

People Team <people@staff-review.example.invalid>

Hello Ama, verify your staff profile within 30 minutes to keep access. Reply with your password and approval code.

Points to check: Unverified staff-review address; Threat of losing access; Request for account secrets

Suggested response: Contact your People Team through the company directory. Report the message without replying.

Workplace checklist

- Check the complete sender address
- Compare the request with expected work
- Verify unusual instructions independently
- Keep passwords and codes private

Further reading

NIST: phishing guidance

Complete this lesson's knowledge check inside PhishAware.

Handle links and attachments

Recognize misleading destinations and handle unexpected files without exposing company data.

Learning goals

- Inspect a destination without opening the site
- Recognize unsafe file instructions
- Use approved checks for confidential files

Read the destination

On a desktop, hovering over a link often reveals the address. Do not open a suspicious destination to inspect the page. On a phone, use a preview only if your device supports viewing without navigation. Otherwise open the service from a known bookmark.

Look at the host, not the branding

For this exercise, `accounts.example.invalid.attacker.test` belongs under `attacker.test`. A trusted-looking word elsewhere in the address does not change the host. HTTPS protects a connection but does not certify the sender or business. Training addresses here are examples, not links to visit.

Treat files as part of the request

An unexpected invoice, archive, executable, or document asking for macros needs verification. Use your approved security process. Avoid uploading confidential files to public scanning services. A clean scan supports assessment, but does not prove a file harmless.

Practice example: Open the revised invoice

Accounts <billing@invoice-review.example.invalid>

Please open Invoice.zip, run the included viewer, and disable security warnings if the document will not load.

Points to check: Unexpected archive; Request to run software; Instruction to disable protection

Suggested response: Do not run the viewer. Verify the invoice with your known supplier contact and report the message.

Workplace checklist

- Inspect the destination without visiting
- Open known services from a bookmark
- Keep macros and security protections unchanged
- Send suspicious files through approved reporting channels

Further reading

Google: avoid and report phishing

Complete this lesson's knowledge check inside PhishAware.

Report and respond to suspicious email

Know how to report concerns and respond after clicking, sharing information, or running a file.

Learning goals

- Report useful details without exposing secrets
- Distinguish reporting from marking a notification read
- Choose next steps after different exposures

Send a useful report

In PhishAware, open Email protection and choose Report suspicious on the finding. A summary goes to your company administrators. Provide the time and actions taken through your approved support channel. Never include passwords, approval codes, or confidential attachments in a complaint.

After a click or credential entry

Stop interacting with the page and contact your security team. Explain whether you clicked, downloaded, entered a password, or approved a prompt. If credentials were entered, use the official service from a trusted device to change the affected password and review account security with your team.

After running a file or sending money

If a file ran or a device behaves unusually, contact your IT team using another device and follow their containment procedure. Avoid deleting evidence or wiping the device. If money moved, contact your finance team and bank immediately through known numbers. Prompt reporting supports investigation.

Practice example: I entered my password

Employee incident example

Kofi followed a document link and typed his work password. The page then requested a second approval. He stopped before approving.

Points to check: Password entered on an unverified page; Further approval requested

Suggested response: Report the credential exposure immediately. Use the official account service and follow security-team instructions for password, sessions, and recovery settings.

Workplace checklist

- Stop further interaction
- Report the time and actions taken
- Never share passwords in reports
- Keep evidence for your security team

Further reading

Google: secure a compromised account

Complete this lesson's knowledge check inside PhishAware.

Verify payments and executive requests

Check invoices, bank detail changes, gift card requests, and urgent instructions.

Learning goals

- Identify payment and executive impersonation
- Verify a bank detail change separately
- Follow approval rules under pressure

Recognize the pattern

Business email compromise exploits workplace trust. A sender posing as a supplier, executive, or employee might request a transfer, gift cards, or changed payment details. The request might arrive in an existing thread, so a familiar conversation alone is insufficient.

Use a separate approval channel

Call a verified contact using the number already held in your supplier or company records. Confirm changes before editing payment details. Follow dual approval and transaction limits wherever your organization requires them. Keep a record of verification through your approved process.

Escalate pressure and secrecy

An instruction to skip checks or keep a transfer secret needs escalation. Email tone, logos, and voice recordings do not replace approval. If a transfer occurred, notify your finance lead and financial institution immediately through established channels.

Practice example: Bank details changed, settle today

Supplier accounts <accounts@supplier-change.example.invalid>

Our previous account is unavailable. Send GHS 18,500 to this replacement account before 3 PM. Please skip the usual callback because the finance lead is busy.

Points to check: Changed bank details; Pressure to bypass verification; Deadline attached to an unverified transfer

Suggested response: Pause the payment. Call the supplier using your existing records and follow company approval rules.

Workplace checklist

- Verify changes with an existing supplier contact
- Keep payment approvals in place
- Escalate secrecy or bypass requests
- Report suspected fraud promptly

Further reading

FBI: business email compromise

Complete this lesson's knowledge check inside PhishAware.

Protect passwords and sign-in approvals

Use unique passwords, approved managers, and multifactor authentication without sharing secrets.

Learning goals

- Keep account secrets separate
- Reject unrequested MFA approvals
- Understand phishing-resistant sign-in methods

Protect each account

Use a unique password for each service and your organization's approved password manager. Reusing a work password elsewhere exposes the work account when another service is breached. Never send passwords or recovery codes in an email, call, or support form.

Approve only your own sign-ins

MFA adds another check, but codes and push approvals still need care. Reject prompts you did not initiate and report repeated prompts. An alleged support caller asking for a code is asking for an account secret. Open the official service to review activity.

Use stronger sign-in methods

Passkeys and supported security keys resist common phishing attempts better than typed codes. Use methods approved for your work account. Protect recovery information, keep backup methods current, and contact your administrator if a work authentication device is lost.

Practice example: IT needs your approval code

Service desk caller example

A caller says your mailbox needs repair and asks for the six-digit sign-in code. Two approval prompts arrive while you are speaking.

Points to check: Code requested by another person; Prompts you did not initiate

Suggested response: Reject the prompts. End the call and contact your real service desk through the directory.

Workplace checklist

- Use unique passwords
- Keep codes and recovery keys private
- Reject unrequested approvals
- Use approved passkeys or security keys where available

Further reading

NIST: multifactor authentication

Complete this lesson's knowledge check inside PhishAware.

Recognize QR codes, texts, and phone scams

Apply verification habits to phones, chat messages, QR codes, and voice calls.

Learning goals

- Treat QR codes as links
- Verify unexpected chat or text requests
- Respond to requests for remote access

Preview a QR destination

A QR code carries a destination without displaying the full address in the message. Before proceeding, inspect the address shown by your scanner. If a message demands a work sign-in, open the approved service independently. Codes in email or on a pasted sticker still need context.

Check requests across channels

The same decision rules apply to SMS, WhatsApp, social messages, and calls. A courier fee or payroll update might be expected, but an unusual demand still needs a separate check. Use a known app or contact, rather than a destination supplied in the message.

Keep control of your device

Do not install remote access software or read out codes for an unverified caller. Hang up and contact your service desk through established details. A familiar voice or incoming caller name is insufficient proof of identity.

Practice example: Scan to retain staff Wi-Fi

Facilities <wifi-reset.example.invalid>

Scan this QR code and enter your work email password now. Do not contact IT because the network migration is confidential.

Points to check: Unexpected sign-in via QR code; Password requested; Discourages independent verification

Suggested response: Open your known staff portal or contact IT through the company directory. Avoid scanning to sign in.

Workplace checklist

- Inspect QR destinations before proceeding
- Reach services through approved apps
- Verify calls independently
- Keep remote access under approved IT control

Further reading

NCSC: QR code risks

Complete this lesson's knowledge check inside PhishAware.

Handle shared documents and data requests

Verify shared files and avoid exposing sensitive information through unusual requests.

Learning goals

- Check document invitations in context
- Confirm who needs access
- Keep confidential content out of public tools

Verify an unexpected invitation

A document-sharing notice might be genuine while the document or requester is untrusted. Check who shared the file and why you need access. Use your known work application to find the document. Do not trust a separate login page because the email uses a familiar logo.

Check the requested access

Before sharing staff lists, customer information, or internal files, confirm the recipient, purpose, and approval. Avoid broad public permissions for work documents. Use your organization's approved sharing settings and ask your administrator when an external request is unclear.

Protect information while seeking help

Report a suspicious file using approved tools. In PhishAware feedback, describe the problem without copying confidential document contents, passwords, or attachments. Avoid uploading sensitive material to public analysis sites or public chat tools without company approval.

Practice example: Share payroll list for audit

External reviewer <audit@review-files.example.invalid>

Upload the full payroll list using this public folder. Set access to anyone with the link so our whole team has access.

Points to check: Sensitive staff data requested; Public sharing requested; Reviewer and purpose not verified

Suggested response: Confirm the request with your authorized audit contact. Use approved restricted sharing only after approval.

Workplace checklist

- Verify the document owner and purpose
- Use your known work application
- Limit sharing to approved recipients
- Describe incidents without exposing confidential contents

Further reading

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Use PhishAware results and reporting

Understand risk labels, notifications, reports, and the limits of email scanning.

Learning goals

- Interpret Low, Medium, and High risk
- Separate review from reporting
- Find read notifications and request help

Treat labels as guidance

PhishAware checks message content for risk indicators. Low risk is not proof of safety. Medium risk calls for verification. High risk deserves prompt attention. The current scanner does not verify linked websites, sender authentication, or attachment contents, so follow your company's process as well.

Choose the action for your decision

Save as reviewed records your review. Report suspicious shares the finding summary with administrators. Mark as read acknowledges a notification and moves the notification out of Active. None of these actions proves the email safe or automatically removes an email from Gmail.

Find help and previous notifications

Use Notifications → History to search read warnings. Use Settings → Contact and feedback for complaints or help requests and select company administrators or platform owners. For an urgent incident, also use your company's direct security contact. Email alert delivery depends on the configured sender and provider.

Practice example: A finding shows Low risk

PhishAware practice example

A Low risk email still asks Ama to move a confidential customer file to an unfamiliar service. She is unsure whether the request is authorized.

Points to check: Unfamiliar destination; Confidential information requested; Risk label is being treated as authorization

Suggested response: Pause and verify the request. Report suspicious if concerns persist, regardless of the Low risk label.

Workplace checklist

- Read reasons and suggested actions
- Verify even when a result is Low risk
- Use Report suspicious for incident escalation
- Use History to find read warnings

Further reading

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